FAMILY CAREER IDENTITY FRAMEWORK

Family Social Science
COLLEGE OF EDUCATION
+ HUMAN DEVELOPMENT

Sarah A. Burcher, MBA
burch184@umn.edu

UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA
Driven to Discover℠

Aims & Goals

Introduction

Literature surrounding career development is plentiful, spanning multiple disciplines. Employment is not only a key function of the individual within society, but also for the well being of the family (Kalleberg, 2008). Economics focuses on job attainment, vocation research focuses on skill development, and social science focuses on individual development (Brown, 2016). Employment is often analyzed as a predictor of success (McLoyd, Kaplan, Purtell & Huston, 2011). With such divided foci, there is a to need synthesize present concepts to effectively understand career identity development within the family and to address the social justice aims of the UN goal of decent work and economic growth.

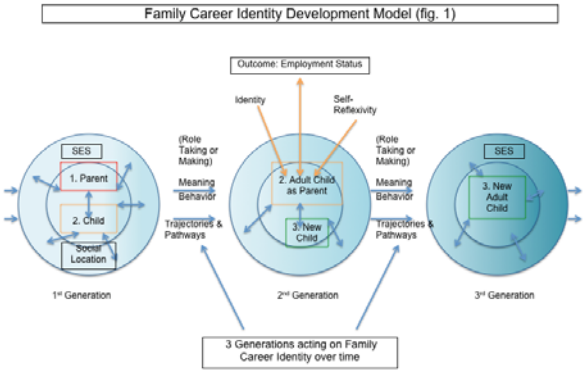
Methods

Research on career identity resulted from seeking to understand why some employment training programs have long-term impact and others struggle. Review and analysis of peer-reviewed articles were compiled that illustrated the stated literature gap. Concepts such as future orientation and possible selves, when developed during adolescent development, can lead to adult employment satisfaction. For adults work motivation centered on successful identity development, though most career theories have a limited acknowledgement of social context or family impact on individual development (Brown, 2016).

Implications

The Family Career Identity Development Framework, with a strong theoretical foundation, introduces an integrated set of concepts, assumptions, within a model, designed to examine family transmission of employment value. Regardless of one's career identity, every adult has an employment status. Understanding why and how career identity is developed, and the continued impact on future employment outcomes, is urgently needed within the family research community in response to the rapidly changing social and economic environment. Meaningful employment is crucial to realize true social justice and economic equity (Brown, 2016).

FCI Model & Assumptions



The Family Career Identity Development Framework (FCI) is designed to capture the nature and meaning of career identity by integrating concepts and assumptions from Symbolic Interactionism Theory, General Systems Theory, and Life Course Perspective Theory. Proposed concepts include identity, interaction/transactional patterns, self-reflexivity, role taking/role making, social location, and trajectories/pathways. Assumptions include:

- The value and purpose of work is directly influenced between parent and child, motivating future behavior.
- The family as a system creates a shared identity that interacts with and reacts to their larger community system.
- The family together makes career goals which are influenced by the community that they belong to, the resources available, and their past positive and negative experiences.
- Families are diverse and change occurs over time, which continues through generations.

Background

Six main themes surrounding employment research literature illustrate the literature gap regarding career identity development and the need to add the family perspective:

1. Career development focuses on individual development.
Career identity, or how one defines themselves in the career context, is not only a key indicator of employability, it is often the main motivator for behavior (Koen, Klehe, & Vianen, 2013). Employability, or one's ability to identify and fulfill career opportunities (Fugate, Kinicki, & Ashforth, 2003) is comprised of adaptability, social capital, human capital, and career identity, all of which play into an individual's capacity to get and keep paid employment. Identity development is shaped partly by individual exploration and commitment activities, but also in the context of collective social networks (Grote & Hall, 2013) and can be impacted by group identities (Shinnar, 2008).

2. Career Identity development has been limited to the school-to-work transition.
Identity exploration surrounding future careers and the purpose for work is commonly a task completed in adolescence or young adulthood (Lucas, 1999), such as the socially accepted time of experimenting with different vocations in college (Stringer & Kerpelman, 2010). However, there are many individual and social characteristics that can impact an individual's opportunities for career exploration and access to employment prospects (Benson, Johnson, & Elder, Jr., 2011; Hirschman & Voloshin, 2007).

3. Career Identity is presented as static once developed and deterministic over time.
Contrary to the concept that one's career identity is developed and determined at specific developmental stages, identity can be dynamic and useful to understand within-individual changes (Markowitz & Salvatore, 2012). Research on adult career transitions or changes indicates that's one career identity can adapt over time. In today's economy it has become increasingly more common that midlife adults are reevaluating their career identity and meaning for work (Witten, 2003).

4. Homogenous samples with limited diversity.
Research on career identity formation has focused on young adults of European descent attending a four-year university. To measure program impact, employment programs measure career identity in the children of program participants, rather than the participants themselves (McLoyd, Kaplan, Purtell & Huston, 2011). Low socioeconomic status has been shown to disrupt stage development as an accumulation of risks over time and prevents the successful completion of normative stage tasks (Kennedy et al., 2010).

5. The meaning and purpose for work is not the same for everyone.
The meaning of employment can be different for marginalized populations (Motulsky, 2010). Perecman and Curran (2006) found that workers understood their wage rate differently from their managers, as the wage was seen as the end goal rather than a means to reach goals of consumption or efficient resource allocation. Parents and socioeconomic status directly influence an adolescent's work perspective (Kerpelman & Mosher, 2009). Work can be a signifier of belonging to a certain social class (Ali, Fall, & Hoffman, 2013) while others integrate past and current work experiences with life events, shaping future employment behaviors (Nazar & Van der Heijden, 2013).

6. Programs, policies and overall access to opportunities vary.
Job-training programs focus on job search skills, resume building or high-intensity job search strategies, rather than career identity development. Programs unintentionally reinforce a two-tiered system between those who have developed their career identity and those who have not (Rocque, Posick, & Paternoster, 2014), assuming everyone has explored career, education, and life options. In one examination of the effect of welfare and employment policies associated with employment-based programs, there were mixed outcomes for participants from different levels of disadvantage (Alderson et al., 2008).

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